What the Law Is For

Exodus 21–24 · Exodus 32–34 · Jeremiah 31:31–34

The big idea: The moral law still binds everyone. It shows us our sin, restrains evil, and guides believers. Israel sealed the covenant with blood and broke it within weeks. God promised a new covenant, with his law written on the heart.

Before you meet: Read

Exodus 24:3–8 | Exodus 32:1–14 | Exodus 34:4–7 | Jeremiah 31:31–34

Open (5 minutes)

Have you ever made a promise you could not keep? What happened?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Behold the _____ of the covenant that the LORD has made with you in accordance with all these words." *(Exodus 24:8)*

Around the golden calf the people said, "These are your _____, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt!" *(Exodus 32:4)*

"The LORD, the LORD, a God _____ and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast _____ and faithfulness." *(Exodus 34:6)*

Discuss

1. The law works as a mirror, a restraint, and a guide. Which one have you experienced most? Explain. *Romans 3:20; Galatians 3:24*

2. Israel promised, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do," and weeks later made a golden calf. Why do you think they turned so fast? What do you turn to when God seems slow? *Exodus 24:7; 32:1–4*

3. Moses asked to be blotted out for Israel and could not be. Jesus was cut off for his people and became a curse for them. What does that tell you about him? *Exodus 32:32–33; Galatians 3:13*

Memory verse

> *"I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts."*
>
> **Jeremiah 31:33**

Pray

Confess one way the law's mirror shows your sin. Thank God that Jesus kept the law for you and bore its curse, and ask him to write it on your heart.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 18

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Exodus 32:1–14 and 34:4–7 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Exodus 25–27).

Main points to land

1. The moral law, summed up in the Ten Commandments, binds everyone. The ceremonial laws pointed to Christ and are fulfilled. Israel's civil laws ended with the nation, though their justice still teaches us (WCF 19.3–5).
2. The law is a mirror that shows our sin and drives us to Christ, a restraint on evil, and a guide for believers. It can no longer condemn those who are in Christ (WCF 19.6).
3. Sinai was a covenant of grace, with a mediator, blood sacrifice, and a merciful God (34:6; WCF 7.5). Israel broke it. Jesus kept the law for us, bore its curse, and brings a better covenant that writes the law on our hearts (Jeremiah 31:33; Hebrews 12:24).

Core doctrine to teach

The Law of God CORE DOCTRINE 9 OF 26

God's moral law, summed up in the Ten Commandments, shows us his holy character. It exposes our sin and drives us to Christ, who kept it perfectly for us. For those who belong to him, it becomes a guide for a grateful life, written on the heart by the Spirit. *Exodus 20:1–17; Romans 3:20; Galatians 3:24; Jeremiah 31:33; Matthew 22:37–40*

Answer key (Observe)

1. blood
2. gods
3. merciful; love

Questions people will ask

Was Israel saved by keeping the law, while we are saved by grace?

No. God rescued Israel before he gave the law, and he gave sacrifices for the times they failed. Believers in Israel were saved by grace through faith in the promised Messiah, just as we are (WCF 7.5). The new covenant brings the same salvation in fuller light.

Closing prayer

Father, we are like Israel at the foot of the mountain: quick to promise and quick to turn away. Thank you that you are merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love. Thank you for Jesus, who kept the law we broke. Amen.